

KEEPING VIGIL Rashtriya Rifles soldiers at the site of an encounter with militants in Lawaypora, near Srinagar, in February 2020

Photographs by ABID BHAT

FORCE REDUCTION

WITH MILITANCY BEATEN BACK IN KASHMIR AND THE GROUND SITUATION INCHING TOWARDS NORMALITY, THERE ARE EFFORTS TO REDUCE THE DEPLOYMENT OF THE COUNTER-INSURGENCY FORCE RASHTRIYA RIFLES. BUT EXPERTS WARN AGAINST A DRASTIC DRAWDOWN

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

THE HOPEFUL ASSESSMENT HAS BEEN REPEATEDLY PRONOUNCED by the Centre and the security forces: normality is finally returning to the Kashmir valley. Terror-related incidents are down, their perpetrators neutralised at an increasing pace and Over Ground Networks (OGWs) dismantled. Proof is near at hand too: 33 years after raging unrest forced it to withdraw in 1989, the Indian Navy has resumed its training centre for NCC cadets at central Kashmir's picturesque Manasbal Lake, with two boats moored on the lakefront. Add to that the much noted opening of a multiplex in the valley, signifying the return of cinema after three decades. Business prospects have been looking up and there has been a surge of tourists this summer. Much